**Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay**

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

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**Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's Sonnet 103**

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in an analysis that focuses on the several comparisons that the speaker offers while arguing that he does not have what it takes as an inspired poet to fully praise the beauty of the person whom he is addressing in Shakespeare's Sonnet 103 "[Alack, what poverty my muse brings forth]"—however the concept ***muse*** is to be understood, include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
assonance,
diction,
iambic pentameter,
imagination,
inversion,
muse,
ploce,
rhyme scheme,
sigmatism,
simile,
tone, and
volta.

NB: The contestant does **not** have to recognize that Shakespeare's muse, his invention, is, indeed, his own imagination. Some younger LitCritters might not recognize the three principal comparisons as similes. This non-recognition should not undercut the strength of the contestant's analysis.

Any well-organized analysis that supports its thesis with more than a couple of supporting instances of comparisons suffices to answer the prompt.

The young writer should recognize that the argument that the speaker is making: that his imagination, his muse, fails to adequately address the beauty that he has encountered turns on similes, as well as additional comparisons. The similes are line 4's "Than when [my argument] hath"; line 12's "Than of [his muse's] graces"; and line 13's "than in my verse can."

Additionally, the speaker's consternation, "Alack, what poverty [. . .] having such a scope" (lines 1-2), suggests a comparison. Line 5's "if I no more can write!" declares a ***now*** against a comparison of a ***before***. Line 7's "That overgoes my blunt invention" is an embedded comparison, as is line 9's "striving to mend," which is purposely followed by "To mar [. . .] that before was well" (line 10).

The LitCritter might recognize the emphasis in line 13's ploce "more, much more" as a form of comparison.*

Implicit in the volta—almost lost in the line's inversion—is a conditional (note, please, the subjunctive mood), which is an explicit comparison in the hypothetical: "Were it not sinful, **then**, striving to mend]" (line 9).

*The *Handbook* fails to address the simple repetition of a word for emphasis as ploce—thus never tested in LC.